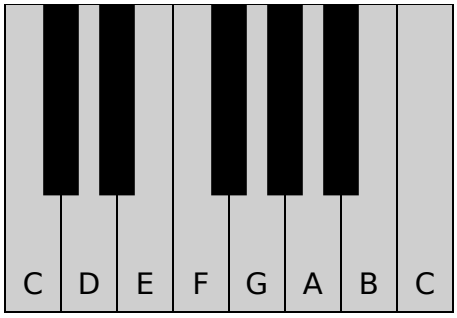
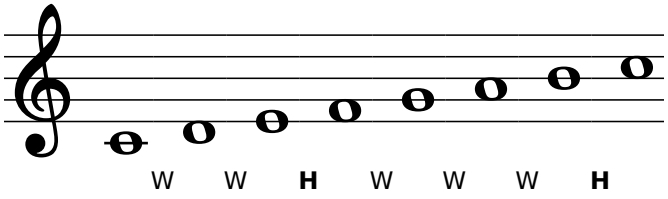
The Major Scale and Key Signatures

A **scale** is a series of notes in alphabetical order, from a starting note up to the same letter an octave higher. The starting note is the **tonic**, and the scale is named for it. A **major scale** follows this pattern of whole steps (W) and half steps (H): **W W H W W W H**. The half steps fall between notes 3 and 4 and between notes 7 and 8. C major uses only white keys.

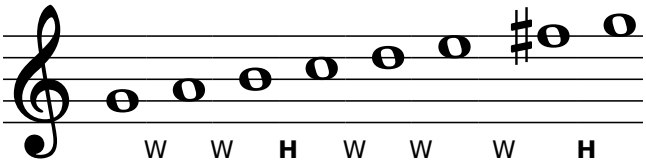


C major: C D E F G A B C

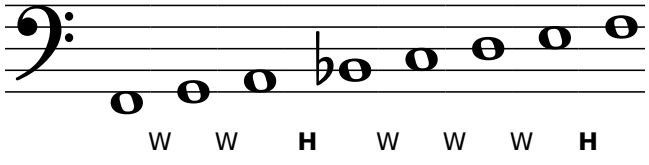


C major on the staff

Every other major scale needs at least one black key to keep the pattern. In G major, the seventh note must be a half step below G, so it is F♯, not F. In F major, the fourth note must be a half step above A, so it is B♭, not B.



G major: one sharp, F♯

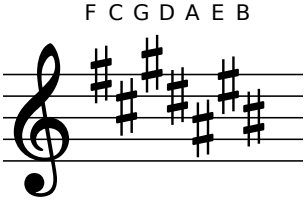


F major: one flat, B♭

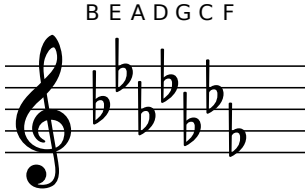
Key signatures

A **key** is the group of notes a piece is built from, named for its tonic: a piece in G major uses the notes of the G major scale, and G is its tonic. A **key signature** is a group of sharps or flats written after the clef at the start of every staff. It applies to every note with those letter names, in every octave, so the accidentals do not need to be written before each note. Sharps and flats in a key signature always appear in a fixed order:
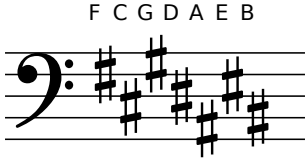
- Order of sharps: F C G D A E B
- Order of flats: B E A D G C F (the order of sharps, reversed)



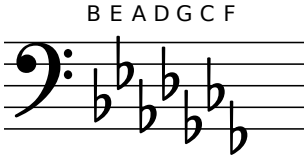
Treble clef, sharps



Treble clef, flats



Bass clef, sharps



Bass clef, flats

This book uses C major and the major keys with up to three sharps (G, D, A) or three flats (F, B♭, E♭).

© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.

Name _____ Date _____

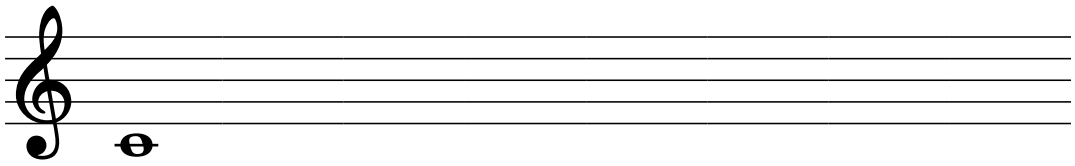
Building Major Scales

A. The major scale pattern Fill in the pattern of whole steps (W) and half steps (H). The first step is given.

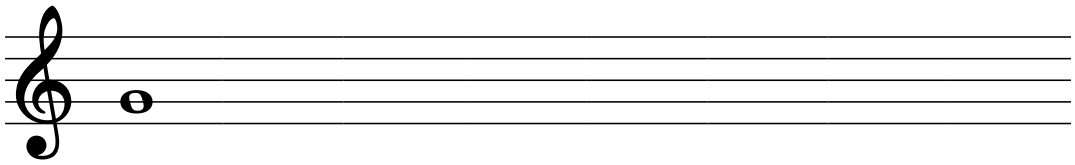
Pattern:	W						

B. Write major scales Write each scale as whole notes, ascending, with the accidentals it needs. Mark each half step with a bracket.

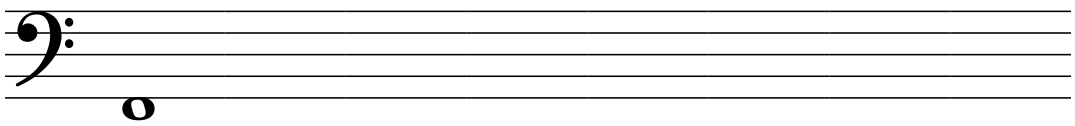
C major



G major

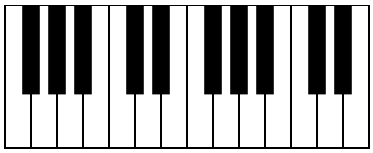


F major

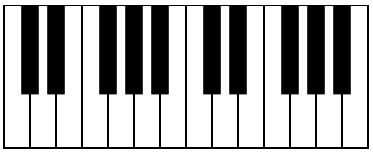


C. Scales on the keyboard Shade the keys of each scale, starting on the lowest key named.

1. A major, starting on A3



2. E♭ major, starting on E♭4



D. Orders of sharps and flats Fill in the order of sharps and the order of flats. The first letter of each is given.

Order of sharps:	F						
Order of flats:	B						

© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.